



WAR OF THE POSES

With appearances on talent shows, news channels, at temples, and even cricket matches, the battle between Diwali's two big releases is in full gear and hey, the movies aren't even out



STAR STRATEGY: Stills of *Om Shanti Om* (top); *Saawariya*

■ By Kaveree Bamzai

On October 18, Sony Pictures threw a party at Mumbai's Hard Rock Café for the Indian and Australian teams, which was a culmination of *Saawariya*'s young stars' appearances during breaks on Neo Sports, asking people to watch their new film. It was part of a carefully calibrated marketing campaign that has seen tie-ups with a retail giant, a

banking company, an insurance firm and even a bubblegum brand (bubblegum for a bubblegum romance, get it?). Two days later, Shah Rukh Khan, the marketing whirlwind behind his home production *Om Shanti Om*, got equal, if not more, mileage by simply turning up to watch the Twenty20 match, with lissome starling, Deepika Padukone, generating free airtime not

only about his lucky streak vis-à-vis the Indian cricket team but also about a possible budding romance between Mahinder Singh Dhoni and Padukone.

Whew. It's a war out there. Between Shah Rukh Khan's six pack, unveiled on news channels with the song *Dard-e-disco*, and Ranbir Kapoor's supposed full monty, hinted at while releasing the new song, *Jab se tere naina*, the two films have stretched public interest in Bollywood to fever pitch. Some would even say to a melodramatic pitch with Shah Rukh portraying it as an issue of nationalism, saying he is up against the multinational might of Columbia Tristar. The Sony camp is readying its own riposte—with director Sanjay Leela Bhansali emphasising that a Western company has come to India to make a film on Bollywood's *naach-gaana* terms.

It's a case of combatant marketing, with each trying to attain ubiquity. Last year, the combined budget of two big Diwali releases—*Don* and *Jaan-e-Mann*, was Rs 70 crore and the total number of prints released was 1,500. This year, the Rs 35 crore-*Saawariya* has spent an additional Rs 20 crore and the Rs 20 crore-*Om Shanti Om* has spent another Rs 5 crore on marketing. Each will release with 1,000 prints. This